

Leibniz's Windmill Argument

The Monadology, §17

G. W. LEIBNIZ (1646–1716)

SOURCE. *The Monadology*, written 1714, first published 1720. Translation by Robert Latta, 1898.

CONTEXT. The *Monadology* is a compressed summary of Leibniz's late metaphysics. Here he asks whether perception could be produced by a machine.

17. Moreover, it must be confessed that *perception* and that which depends upon it are *inexplicable on mechanical | grounds*, that is to say, by means of figures and motions. And supposing there were a machine, so constructed as to think, feel, and have perception, it might be conceived as increased in size, while keeping the same proportions, so that one might go into it as into a mill. That being so, we should, on examining its interior, find only parts which work one upon another, and never anything by which to explain a perception. Thus it is in a simple substance, and not in a compound or in a machine, that perception must be sought for. Further, nothing but this (namely, perceptions and their changes) can be found in a simple substance. It is also in this alone that all | the *internal activities* of simple substances can consist.